## THE POWER TRIO

**Mohan Charan Majhi,** *52*
*Chief Minister, Odisha*
**Background** Fourth-term MLA from Keonjhar, north Odisha; former chief whip of the Opposition
**USP:** Tribal leader

**Kanak Vardhan Singh Deo,** *62*
*Deputy chief minister*
**Background** Sixth-term MLA from Patnagarh, west Odisha; former state BJP chief, former minister
**USP:** Royal lineage

**Pravati Parida,** *57*
*Deputy chief minister*
**Background:** Debutant MLA from Nimapara, coastal Odisha
**USP:** OBC leader

Rajendra Narayan Singh Deo, as the most assertive of the trio at the top—a man with a mind of his own. "It is quite surprising that our central leaders chose Kanak Babu as deputy CM. He is unlikely to take high command diktats. He has fallen out with the party in the past," says a source.

Another challenge for Majhi will be to handle the bureaucrats, given the perception that predecessor Patnaik gave senior officers a free hand in the last 10 years of his regime, the prominence of former bureaucrat V.K. Pandian in decision-making being an index. "From continuing with the better welfare schemes of Patnaik to bringing all stakeholders on the same page while delivering on high command orders, Majhi will have many things to consider," says Mishra. One of them went to script, though: his first cabinet decision was to open all four doors of the Puri Jagannath temple. ■

some divine help could do no harm. So, it was only after a few prayers at daybreak at Tirumala on June 13 that Naidu reached the secretariat for the first time after taking charge. Files pertaining to poll promises were soon being signed: the one to recruit about 13,000 teachers, and to repeal the Land Titling Act that the previous Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party government had been trying to implement. His other orders included enhancing the social security pension to Rs 4,000 a month from Rs 3,000 and initiating a skill census.

Naidu is also determined to return to his pet projects—Amaravati and the Polavaram lift irrigation scheme—declaring his intent intent before assuming office. Shelving the tri-capital plan of his predecessor Jagan Mohan, Naidu insisted that Amaravati will remain the state's sole capital. But he did assure that Visakhapatnam, where Jagan had planned to shift the state administration, will be developed as Andhra's financial capital, and the growth needs of Kurnool, which Jagan had proposed as the state's judicial capital, attended to as well. By doing so, Naidu is being mindful of the competing regional aspirations in the state and nnot entirely overturning what Jagan was trying to accomplish.

The TDP, of course, is expected to lead the coalition show. "It will call the shots with some low-end accommodation of the BJP and JSP and the probability of both parties working in close quarters are brighter," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad. Andhra Pradesh still does not have a capital almost a decade after its bifurcation. But besides settling the capital city conundrum, Naidu's list of priorities includes providing employment in the organised sector, improving infrastructure like roads and, most importantly, getting special category status for his state, to get funds that he can use to fast-track development.

"The people have done their part to save the state," Naidu said. "The onus lies on us to ensure that their aspirations and expectations are fulfilled. Our responsibilities have increased manifold." While cornering a respectable 57 per cent vote share, the alliance lost just 11 assembly seats—an overwhelming majority that the TDP did not get in any of its previous mandates.

**NAIDU WILL RETURN TO PET PROJECTS AMARAVATI AND POLAVARAM, BUT WILL ALSO STRIVE FOR SPECIAL CATEGORY STATUS FOR AP**

Given the huge trust and hope that the Andhra electorate has vested in him along with the fact that, at 74, this will probably be the last leg of his illustrious political career, Naidu will most definitely want to leave a permanent mark in the state's history. "He now finds himself in the best situation," says political commentator Dendukuri Gautam, "with a dominating mandate in the state and an important ally at the Centre where his support is the lifeline." An able administrator, Naidu's style of functioning is likely to remain the same, but he will certainly be aggressive in soliciting funds to ensure he fulfils Andhra's development aspirations within this term. "He will most definitely make the most of the situation and it remains to be seen how obliging the BJP will be to dole out favours periodically," says Gautam. "They have the whole country to look after this electoral debacle with a sizeable Opposition breathing down." That won't stop Naidu from demanding his pound of flesh. ■